

COMPARISON · SPLIT · STRUCTURE

before-after

Explicit state-change comparison — what was, what is.

What writing decisions down actually changed.

BEFORE .

Decisions lived in the room they were made in. Six months on, nobody could say why we killed the project — only that someone senior had felt strongly. Every quarter relitigated the same three debates from memory.



AFTER .

Every decision is logged with its signals, its options, and the bet it made. We still relitigate, but now there is a record showing we already decided this in March. We ignore it, but faster.

What the operating review changed.

BEFORE

Status arrived as a 40-slide deck nobody finished; the real decision happened in the hallway afterward.



AFTER

One scorecard, one page; the call is logged in the room before anyone leaves.

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When NOT to reach for before-after.

Two competing options. Use `compare-prose` or `split-compare` when both sides are alternatives under consideration. before-after is for a change that already happened.

More than two states. If there is a middle state or a sequence of changes, use `list-steps` to show the progression. before-after is binary by construction.

Editorial labels on the cards. The card label is always Before or After. Renaming them to Old way / New way defeats the universal grammar and breaks reader expectations.

See also.

RELATED COMPONENTS

`compare-prose` — two alternatives being weighed, not a transformation

`split-compare` — binary decision with a verdict bar

`redline` — the change is in verbatim text, not structural state

`list-steps` — the change has more than two phases